agreement may have been forged out of a worry that local commanders and forces were too close to the action and could lose sight of the bigger strategic picture. Cooler heads in Delhi and Beijing were needed to supplement local efforts at peacemaking.

Unfortunately, the working mechanism didn't work, just as the confidence-building measures didn't build much confidence. In 2013, six months after the three-week stand-off in the Daulat Beg Oldie/Depsang area, India and China signed the Border Defence Cooperation Agreement (BDCA). The BDCA endorsed earlier mechanisms. The two sides were also to cooperate on a slew of other challenges at the border such as the smuggling of arms, wildlife, and contraband as also to work together on natural disasters and infectious diseases. The agreement endorsed meetings between local border units, regional commands, the defence ministries, and the working mechanism of the foreign ministries. At the border it recommended institutionalizing meetings in all sectors, improvements in local telecommunications, and the start of a hotline between the military headquarters. It suggested that front-line troops should meet to celebrate together in various ways and even consider joint training exercises. More to the point, and less ethereally, they were to avoid tailing each other's patrols, particularly in areas where they disagreed on the alignment of the LAC.

Growing confrontation

Less than a year after the signing of the BDCA, the two sides were back to confronting each other. The journalist Srijan Shukla provides an insightful summary of the 2014 and other confrontations. In September 2014, even as President Xi Jinping sat on a swing with Prime Minister Modi in Gujarat during their summit, Indian and Chinese troops glowered at each other in Ladakh after Indian forces had tried to stop the Chinese extending a road from Chepzi to Chumar. The PLA also pushed their civilians into Indian areas of Demchok to stop India building a canal. India had to rush two battalions of troops to reinforce its position, before the crisis simmered